in my mind but that he would go through with the agreement in any event."[92] However, Komer's record of the meeting only notes that the president "was favorably impressed *in principle* with Chet's pitch that it might be possible to trade off a 5-year US military commitment … for at least a tacit understanding that the Indians would not exceed certain reasonable force goals, would limit their buys from the Soviets, and would take a more active role in our grand strategy against China" (emphasis added). While this record notes that Kennedy thought Bowles had an "interesting proposition," it does not indicate that the president had approved such a proposal. Instead the president had "asked that he be given a preliminary Washington view" before he met Bowles again.[93]

Furthermore, it is not clear that India would have agreed to meet the US conditions. While the two countries might have reached an implicit understanding on force goals, the years ahead would show that India was unwilling to take on a more active role in US strategy against China in places like Southeast Asia. In the near term, India would also not agree—then or later—to limit its purchases from the Soviet Union.

The Kennedy administration was not happy about Delhi turning to Moscow. It was concerned both about the potential reaction from Congress and that India would end up overspending on defense if both the American and Soviet stores were open to it.[94]

For India, however, continuing to exercise the Soviet option allowed the government to return to maintaining multiple partnerships and diversifying its dependence. The Soviet attitude during the war had increased questions about the reliability of not just Moscow but external benefactors more broadly. The Indian defense minister noted that other countries' willingness to give India aid depended on their political attitudes, which were apt to change.[95] Moreover, US pressure on India to settle with Pakistan and limit its defense expenditures had highlighted the downside of overdependence on a single source.[96] Both these instances reinforced the Indian inclination to diversify dependency as long as Delhi lacked the ability to eliminate that reliance entirely.

India's tilt toward the US during the war had been the result of a certain set of circumstances, including the lack of availability of the Soviet option. In the aftermath of the war, the Soviet option had become available again. A few days after the war ended, Khrushchev had expressed the hope that India